

Akhila Anya Pisupati

POL S 384 Reading Response 2

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Fisher and Nasrin start strong by describing the methods climate activists employ in their civic engagement and mobilization efforts, to protect the planet and encourage governments to also do so. It sounds impractical coming from an everyday citizen, but “the rise of an ‘international environmental regime’...is associated with lower levels of environmental degradation”, so it is critical that those in positions of power become convinced to act strongly and quickly (Fisher and Nasrin, 2020). By and large, activism pressures powerful actors, such as governments and even multinational corporations, to change institutions and norms on large scales. Most powerfully, shareholder activism and cooperative board stewardship, as well as public product boycotts through transnational advocacy networks, can target the economic sector, pressuring the true villains behind environmental damage to change their behavior.

To contrast this hopeful story of existing action, the WRI has a sad precautionary tale unless we phase out fossil fuels and halt deforestation today. But we have met only one of our 42 goals, while the world burns more coal than ever. The Paris Agreement and a following IPCC report emphasized the need to stay only 1.5 degrees C above pre-industrial levels (around the years 1850-1900) in global average temperature. This is close to being surpassed, especially when considering the atmospheric concentration of carbon dioxide in 2024 “reached its highest level in 2 million years” (Fransen, 2025). While we are still below that 1.5 C threshold, the data and existing trends suggest we have entered already the 20-year period where we will exceed that limit; even fractional increases lead to societal and economic impacts nearly impossible to adapt to. These rises in temperatures will leave nearly one billion people lacking clean water and put 14% of the world’s species at risk of extinction. This depressing outlook calls back to the public activism styles that Fisher and Nasrin document, where many youth movements shout phrases like “1.5 to stay alive” to emphasize how all leaders should understand all of our livelihoods are at stake, even theirs, when engaging in global environmental politics.

But we do not want to abandon this target, even if it seems unrealistic. As Hadden and Prakash highlight, this goal allows for coalition building and mobilization by attracting diverse groups, allowing climate activists to take both an environmental and social justice lens in their outreach. Moreover, being able to name and shame particular countries that are hurting the climate, through either inaction or negative action, is most effective in pressuring these actors, showing clear norms to which they can be held accountable (Hadden and Prakash, 2024). Shifting the goalposts allows these sneaky corporations and state actors to find a way out, potentially arguing that they could not realistically meet a standard that keeps changing or is too complicated. These avoidance tactics likely contribute to our current dire state that Fransen depicts, where some scientists push for a 2 degree C threshold, knowing that if we meet it, we will see the utter destruction of coral reefs and outright normalize extreme heatwaves.

And there is still hope, if only because there always is. NPR writes about Vienna as a beacon of climate legislation dreams: two years ago, they required all new buildings to add solar panels. They have built massive heat pumps, invested in new infrastructure to adapt to natural disasters, and hope to get their net pollution to zero by 2040. 70 percent of global carbon dioxide emissions come from cities, so it seems clear that guided activism where it counts most can make a big difference. There is a sense of urgency underlying each of these articles: the need to act carefully and thoroughly, but near-instantaneously, in order to avoid irreversible damage to our planet.

These readings all make clear how environmental policy is not just governmental; NGOs, IGOs, scientists, businesses, and everyday citizens stand their ground and guide the discourse on climate change too. From using protests and strikes to sell their point to changing their own consumer behavior, citizen action demonstrates a tangible way to promote climate resilience. Only focusing on environmental law and treaties overlooks the meaningful and extensive activism in the private sphere, where pushing for accountability in legislative and economic settings has been effective and longstanding.

Plus, the NPR article in particular highlights how *successful* climate action in global environmental politics does not have to always be widespread or at the highest level of government. Political agendas often get in the way in these high levels, where a conservative government that is even temporarily in power can totally wreck the climate agenda that took even decades to build up. The role of the public and local governments in creating mindful climate legislation that works for that region can still lead to meaningful environmental restoration overall, if done in many places, as opposed to sweeping change that is difficult to realistically impose given barriers in political opinion.

However, there are still some doubts. For one, we are left unaware as to which theory of change (according to Fisher and Nasrin) is the most effective when dealing with government. It seems clear that governments often react poorly to outright strikes, akin to what JUST STOP OIL does. Moreover, the effectiveness can often vary depending on the political party in power, or even the race and gender and socioeconomic class of those doing the activism, depending what institutional barriers are in place in a given state. These effects have not been thoroughly studied, and especially in far-right governments where outspokenness can have deadly consequences, it is crucial for activists to understand what approach still protects their safety and well-being.

Additionally, Fisher and Nasrin mention both that digital activism, after the COVID-19 pandemic, did play a notable role in the school climate strikes and that far-right governments have generally less concern for the environment. It is crucial to know the true impact of these radical voices on online environmental justice: these days, everyone with an Internet connection has a (mostly) equal opportunity to push their agenda on any issue, regardless of how extreme it

may be. Especially since political figures also have strong social media presences, the effect of each political belief on guiding the discourse online that inevitably bleeds into the real world is important both for climate policy and understanding interpersonal relationships.

Finally, we do not know if keeping 1.5 degree C limit will help truly, even as it may scarily become outdated soon. It is a matter of science versus marketing, where in a perfect world, we should respect the experts and the most updated information. However, when so much of climate activism is just convincing state leaders to listen for even a few seconds, pushing for accountability must be clear-cut and fast. This does, however, sacrifice some more hopeful goals, so the better choice has not been illuminated just yet. We would hope it was so that we can guide our outreach efforts most efficiently and effectively, which is the overarching goal for any activist.

Works Cited

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